

THE CONSTITUTION & BY-LAWS



The Ancient Order of Free Gardeners, Inc.

Published by the United Council, A.O.F.G.

Under the Corporate Seal of the
Ancient Order of Free Gardeners Inc.

2025 Edition, First Revision

AUTHORIZATION

This Constitution and By-Laws were created under the authority of the United Council. This latest edition replaces any previous versions.



The Ethics Committee
The Preservation and Instruction Committee
Ancient Order of Free Gardeners

TABLE OF CONTENTS

CHAPTER I: Constiution of the Ancient Order of Free Gardeners	10
ARTICLE I : PURPOSE AND PROVISIONS	10
ARTICLE II : UNITED COUNCIL MEMBERSHIP	10
Section 2.01 Membership.	10
Section 2.02 Membership Criteria.	10
Section 2.03 Meetings.	11
Section 2.04 Notice of Meetings.	11
Section 2.05 Quorum.	11
Section 2.06 Voting.	11
Section 2.07 Proxy.	11
Section 2.08 Action without a Meeting.	12
Section 2.09 Committee Members.	12
ARTICLE III : MEMBRESHIP IN THE ORDER	12
Section 3.01 Membership.	12
Section 3.02 Membership Criteria.	12
Section 3.03 Regalia.	12
Section 3.04 Attire.	12
ARTICLE IV : LODGE STRUCTURE	13
Section 4.01 Grand Lodges.	13
Section 4.02 Authority and Responsibilities.	13
Section 4.03 Compliance.	13
Section 4.04 Constituent Lodges.	13
(a) Duties and Responsibilities.	14
Section 4.05 Compliance.	14
Section 4.06 Independent Lodges.	14
(a) Authority and Responsibilities.	14
Section 4.07 Compliance.	15
Section 4.08 Commissions.	15
(a) Authority and Scope.	15
Section 4.09 Issuance and Jurisdictional Limits.	15
(a) Expiration and Transition to Charter.	15
Section 4.10 Supervision.	15

Section 4.11	Charters.	15
Section 4.12	Issuance and Authority.	15
(a)	Rights Conferred.	15
(b)	Custody and Revocation.	16
ARTICLE V : ADMINISTRATIVE AUTHORITY		16
ARTICLE VI :UNITED COUNCIL: AUTHORITY AND ELECTIONS		16
Section 6.01	Council Powers and Number.	17
Section 6.02	Election and Term of Office.	17
Section 6.03	Qualifications for Directorship.	17
Section 6.04	Vacancies.	17
Section 6.05	Removal.	17
Section 6.06	Resignation.	17
Section 6.07	Meetings.	17
Section 6.08	Notice of Meetings.	18
Section 6.09	Quorum.	18
Section 6.10	Voting.	18
Section 6.11	Meeting by Remote Communication.	18
Section 6.12	Action without a Meeting.	19
Section 6.13	Director Compensation.	19
ARTICLE VII : COMMITTEES		19
Section 7.01	Committees of the Council.	19
Section 7.02	Quorum and Action by Committee.	19
Section 7.03	Alternate Members.	19
Section 7.04	Committee Officers.	19
Section 7.05	Duties of Committees.	20
ARTICLE VIII : DIRECTORS, EMPLOYEES, AND AGENTS		20
Section 8.01	Directors.	20
Section 8.02	Election, Term of Office, and Qualifications.	20
Section 8.03	Removal.	21
Section 8.04	Resignations.	21
Section 8.05	Vacancies.	21
Section 8.06	Chairman.	21
Section 8.07	Vice Chairman.	21
Section 8.08	Secretary-General.	21
Section 8.09	Treasurer.	21

Section 8.10	Archivist.....	22
Section 8.11	Employees and Other Agents.....	22
Section 8.12	Compensation.....	22
ARTICLE IX : AMENDMENTS		22
Section 9.01		22
ARTICLE X : NON-DISCRIMINATION		22
Section 10.01		22
ARTICLE XI : REFERENCE TO CERTIFICATE OF INCORPORATION.....		22
Section 11.01		22
ARTICLE XII : GENERAL PROVISIONS.....		23
Section 12.01	Fiscal Year.	23
Section 12.02	Seal.	23
(a)		23
Section 12.03	Books and Records.....	23
Section 12.04	Records Retention and Destruction Policy.	23
Section 12.05	Annual Returns; Necessary Filings.. ..	23
Section 12.06	Electronic Signatures.....	23
CHAPTER ii: Grand Lodges of the Ancient Order of Free Gardners		24
ARTICLE I : NAME AND OPERATION		24
Section 1.01	Name.....	24
Section 1.02	Organization.....	24
Section 1.03	Purpose.....	24
Section 1.04	Objectives.....	24
Section 1.05	Interest of the United Council.....	24
Section 1.06	Authority.....	24
Section 1.07	Non-Interference Policy.....	24
Section 1.08	Charters and Commissions.	25
Section 1.09	Headquarters.	25
ARTICLE II : GRAND LODGE OFFICERS		25
Section 2.01	Qualifications of Grand Lodge Officers.	25
Section 2.02	Elected Officers.	25
Section 2.03	Appointed Officers.....	25
Section 2.04	Term of Grand Lodge Officers.....	25
Section 2.05	Most Worthy Grand Master.....	26

Section 2.06	Most Worthy Grand Emissary Master.	26
Section 2.07	Most Worthy Grand Secretary.	26
Section 2.08	Most Worthy Grand Rentmaster.	26
Section 2.09	Most Worthy Grand Instruction Master.	26
Section 2.10	Right Worthy Grand Chaplain.	27
Section 2.11	Right Worthy Grand Gatekeeper.	27
Section 2.12	Right Worthy Grand Keyholder.	27
Section 2.13	Grand Lodge Committees.	27
Section 2.14	Quorum and Action by Committee.	28
Section 2.15	Alternate Members.	28
Section 2.16	Grand Lodge Committee Officers.	28
Section 2.17	Duties of Committees.	28
(a)	Ceremonial Standards Committee	28
(b)	Growth and Expansion Committee	28
(c)	Ethics Committee.	28
(d)	Preservation and Instruction Committee.	28
(e)	Public Relations and Communication Committee.	28
(f)	Financial Oversight Committee	29
ARTICLE III : GRAND LODGE MEETINGS.		29
Section 3.01	Regular Meetings.	29
(a)	Annual Planning Meeting.	29
Section 3.02	Purpose.	29
Section 3.03	Quorum.	29
Section 3.04	Notice and Agenda.	30
Section 3.05	Committee Meetings.	30
ARTICLE IV : Biennial Grand Session.		30
Section 4.01	Grand Lodge Session.	30
Section 4.02	Timing and Location.	30
Section 4.03	Delegation and Representation.	30
Section 4.04	Agenda and Proceedings.	30
Section 4.05	Rules of Order.	30
Section 4.06	Biennial Grand Session Planning Committee.	30
(a)	Composition.	30
(b)	Duties and Responsibilities.	31
(c)	Authority and Accountability.	31

Section 4.07	Dates.	31
Section 4.08	Registration Process.	32
(a)	Online Registration.	32
(b)	Mail-In Registration.	32
(c)	In-Person Registration.	32
Section 4.09	Payment Methods.	32
(a)	Credit or Debit Card.	32
(b)	Check or Money Order	32
(c)	Electronic Transfer.	32
Section 4.10	Time Frames and Deadlines.	32
Section 4.11	Confirmation and Credentials.	32
Section 4.12	Refunds and Transfers.	32
Section 4.13	Resolutions and Amendments.	32
ARTICLE V : GRAND LODGE NOMINATIONS AND ELECTIONS		33
Section 5.01	Nominations and Elections.	33
Section 5.02	Grand Lodge Election Committee.	33
(a)	Current Grand Lodge officers.	33
(b)	Members of the balloting committee	33
(c)	Remaining eligible members in attendance.	33
Section 5.03	Balloting.	33
Section 5.04	Installation.	33
ARTICLE VI : BOARD OF GRAND MASTERS		34
Section 6.01	Establishment and Composition.	34
Section 6.02	Purpose and Authority.	34
Section 6.03	Advisory Role.	34
Section 6.04	Meetings and Service.	34
Section 6.05	Recognition and Preservation of Honor.	34
CHAPTER III: CONSTITUENT LODGES AND INDEPENDENT LODGES.		34
ARTICLE I : Name and operation.		34
Section 1.01	Name.	34
Section 1.02	Organization.	35
Section 1.03	Purpose.	35
Section 1.04	Objectives.	35
Section 1.05	Interest of the United Council.	35
Section 1.06	Interest of the Grand Lodge.	35

Section 1.07	Authority.....	35
Section 1.08	Non-Interference Policy.....	35
Section 1.09	Charters and Commissions.	36
Section 1.10	Lodge Hall.	36
ARTICLE II : LODGE OFFICERS.....		36
Section 2.01	Qualifications of Lodge Officers.	36
Section 2.02	Elected Officers.	36
Section 2.03	Appointed Officers.....	36
Section 2.04	Term of Grand Lodge Officers.	36
Section 2.05	Worthy Master.	36
Section 2.06	Emissary Master.....	37
Section 2.07	Secretary.	37
Section 2.08	Rentmaster.....	37
Section 2.09	Instruction Master.	37
Section 2.10	Chaplain.....	38
Section 2.11	Gatekeeper.....	38
Section 2.12	Keyholder.....	38
Section 2.13	Lodge Committees.....	38
Section 2.14	Quorum and Action by Committee.	38
Section 2.15	Alternate Members.	39
Section 2.16	Lodge Committee Officers.	39
Section 2.17	Duties of Committees.	39
(a)	Ceremonial Standards Committee.....	39
(b)	Growth and Expansion Committee.	39
(c)	Ethics Committee.....	Error! Bookmark not defined.
(d)	Preservation and Instruction Committee.....	39
(e)	Public Relations and Communication Committee.....	39
(f)	Financial Oversight Committee.	39
ARTICLE III : LODGE MEETINGS.....		39
Section 3.01	Regular Meetings.	39
(a)	Annual Planning Meeting.	40
Section 3.02	Resolutions and Amendments.....	40
Section 3.03	Purpose.....	40
Section 3.04	Quorum.....	40
Section 3.05	Notice and Agenda.	41

Section 3.06	Committee Meetings.	41
ARTICLE IV : LODGE NOMINATIONS AND ELECTIONS		41
Section 4.01	Nominations and Elections.	41
Section 4.02	Lodge Election Committee.	41
(a)	Current Lodge officers.	41
(b)	Members of the balloting committee.	41
(c)	Remaining eligible members in attendance.	41
Section 4.03	Balloting.	41
Section 4.04	Installation.	41

CHAPTER I: CONSTITUTION OF THE ANCIENT ORDER OF FREE GARDENERS

ARTICLE I: PURPOSE AND PROVISIONS

Section 1.01 The purposes of the Order shall be to promote the moral, intellectual, spiritual and social welfare of its members and surrounding communities through fellowship and service. The purpose of the United Council shall be to ensure the integrity of the Order is maintained by the Grand Lodges, Lodges, and members of the Ancient Order of Free Gardeners, while promoting the growth and harmony of the Order.

Section 1.02 The Order remains steadfast in its enduring commitment to educating its members and the broader community in the fulfillment of their duties, with the goal of fostering the intellectual, moral, social, and spiritual well-being of all who join or engage with the Ancient Order of Free Gardeners.

Section 1.03 The Ceremonial (“Ceremonies”) of the Order shall serve as the highest authority governing the conduct of all Lodges, Grand Lodges, and their members—Constituent only to the Certificate of Incorporation and followed in precedence by the Constitution and By-Laws.

Section 1.04 The administration and stewardship of the Ancient Order of Free Gardeners shall be entrusted to a body known as the United Council, Ancient Order of Free Gardeners (referred to herein as “the United Council” or “the Council”).

Section 1.05 The United Council shall serve as the source of all true and legitimate Free Gardenery under the name of the Ancient Order of Free Gardeners and holds overarching administrative and supervisory authority over the Order.

Section 1.06 – Grand Lodges and Independent Lodges chartered by the United Council shall act as the principal authorities of Free Gardenery within their respective jurisdictions and shall independently exercise final and supervisory control over the Order within the boundaries (area) defined by their charters.

ARTICLE II: UNITED COUNCIL MEMBERSHIP

Section 2.01 Membership. Membership in shall consist of Director Members (“Directors”), United Council Committee Members and General Members (“the Assembly”). The Directors are as follows: Chairman, Vice-Chairman, Secretary-General, Treasurer and Archivist. The Committee Members shall consist of general members of the Order who serve on committees by appointment who are not Directors.

Section 2.02 Membership Criteria. Membership on the Council is open to all members of the Ancient Order of Free Gardeners who have received the Third Degree (“Master Gardener Degree”) and have been duly elected or appointed to serves on the Council by majority vote of the members present during the Grand Conference.

Section 2.03 Meetings. The Council shall meet formally four (4) times during the year for the purpose of delivering quarterly committee reports and transaction of any other business that comes before Council (January, April, July and October) . A Grand Assembly shall be held every three years at the place (including by electronic means such as a website providing conference services), time, and date, as may be fixed by the Council, and all details of the same shall be made announced to the membership of the Order two years in advance. The Grand Assembly shall be a weekend conference open to the Entire Membership (Assembly) of the Order for the purpose of electing new directors, voting on resolutions for amendments to the Bylaws of the Order, camaraderie and networking among members. Special meetings of the United Council shall be held whenever called by resolution of the Chairman, or by a written request of any member of the Council eligible to vote. Special meetings of the Assembly shall be held whenever called by the resolution of a significant number of lodges and/or grand lodges, or by a written request of any member of the Council eligible to vote. Special Assembly meetings should be held virtually or hybrid to ensure the easy attendance of the Entire Membership. The Secretary General, upon receiving a written request or resolution, shall promptly give notice of such a meeting as provided in Section 3.04.

Section 2.04 Notice of Meetings. Written notice of the place, date, and hour of any meeting shall be given to each Council Member entitled to vote at such a meeting by mailing the notice by first class mail with postage prepaid, by personal delivery, or by email not less than ten (10) nor more than fifty (50) days before the date of the meeting. Notice of any meeting other than the regular quarterly meeting of the United Council shall indicate the person or persons calling the meeting, and notice of any special meeting shall also indicate the purpose(s) for which it is called. Only members of the Council are permitted to attend the quarterly meetings unless otherwise permitted by the Chairman.

Section 2.05 Quorum. At all meetings of United Council, fifty percent (50%) of the United Council eligible to vote, present in person or virtually (video conference), shall constitute a quorum for the transaction of business. In the absence of a quorum, the Chairman shall adjourn the meeting from that time until a quorum is present. Notice of the new meeting is required.

Section 2.06 Voting. Except as otherwise provided by statute or these by-laws, the vote of a majority of the United Council present at the time of a vote, if a quorum is present at such time, shall be the act of the United Council. At any meeting of the United Council, each Director Member present shall be entitled to one (1) vote. At all elections of new Directors, the voting may but need not be by ballot and a plurality of the votes of the membership present at the meeting entitled to vote on all matters of business that come before the Council.

Section 2.07 Proxy. Every Director Member entitled to vote at a meeting of United Council or to express consent or dissent. Directors unable to attend a meeting may authorize another Director or member of the Board of Grand Masters to stand in as their proxy for the sake of voting. Every proxy must be in writing and signed by the Director Member or by email setting forth information from which it can be reasonably determined that the proxy was authorized by such Director Member. No proxy shall be valid after the date of the Council meeting noted in their Proxy Authorization or eleven (11) months from the date thereof unless otherwise provided in the proxy. Every proxy shall be revocable at the pleasure of the Director Member executing it

if they appear in person or virtually during the Council meeting before a vote is called. For the purposes of conducting meetings, all proxies shall be delivered to the Secretary-General or, upon the absence of a Secretary-General, the presiding Director Member appointed to act as Secretary-General during the meeting.

Section 2.08 Action without a Meeting. Action may be taken without a meeting on written consent (which can be solicited by the Order and returned by the United Council in electronic form, such as email) setting forth the action to be taken, signed by such United Council as would be required to take the relevant action at a meeting. Such consent may be written or electronic. If consent is electronic it must be able to be reasonably determined to have been sent by the Director Member. In the event action is taken by written consent, the Members not voting thereon or not solicited to vote thereon shall be given prompt notice of actions taken by written consent without a meeting.

Section 2.09 Committee Members. As noted in Section 3.01, Committee Members shall not have voting or other substantive management, governance, or control rights over the Council. The Directors may elect to call a meeting of the Committee Members, at its discretion, on such terms as it deems fit. The Council may further seek the informal, non-binding guidance of the Committee Members in connection with any issue, topic, or decision to be made, or may solicit the assistance of the Board of Grand Masters with respect to an issue, topic, or decision to be made, or to ensure an independent decision in the case of a decision or transaction involving a conflict of interest affecting one or more Director members.

ARTICLE III: MEMBRESHIP IN THE ORDER

Section 3.01 Membership. The Order shall consist of members who have been regularly initiated within the body of a duly chartered or commissioned lodge of the Ancient Order of Free Gardeners.

Section 3.02 Membership Criteria. Membership shall be open to men of good moral character who have expressed their desire to join the Order by applying for membership. The minimum age requirement shall be eighteen (18), and Lodges may elect to be co-ed (both male and female) as their own discretion and by virtue of their prescribed by-laws.

Section 3.03 Regalia. The standard regalia of the Order shall be that which is prescribed in the Ceremonial degrees of the same. The Free Gardener's Sash shall be the only ceremonial regalia permitted to be worn at public events and only with the approval of the presiding officer at the time (i.e. Worthy Master).

Section 3.04 Attire. The attire for ceremonial meetings of the order shall be business attire, namely dark suits (black or navy) and a white collared shirt with an appropriate tie. Female members shall also wear business attire, namely black or navy dress or business suits (slacks or skirts) with white blouse. The attire for formal events shall be black tuxedos for male members and black evening gowns with evening/opera gloves for women; with Sash (unless otherwise instructed). Formal events may include but are not limited to: Banquets; White Garden Lodge and Garden Table Ceremonies. The approved attire for official events must always be communicated in advance to members and guests.

ARTICLE IV: LODGE STRUCTURE

Section 4.01 Grand Lodges. A Grand Lodge of the Ancient Order of Free Gardeners shall be the highest authority and central governing body within a designated jurisdiction of the Order, as prescribed in an official commission or charter from the United Council. It serves as regional guardian and steward of the Order's traditions, ceremonies, and guiding principles, ensuring harmony and unity among all Constituent Lodges under its care, under the auspices of the United Council of the Ancient Order of Free Gardeners.

Section 4.02 Authority and Responsibilities. The Grand Lodge shall hold stewardship or supervisory authority over all Constituent Lodges and shall not interfere in the business of any Constituent Lodge unless deemed necessary due to severe violations of the Constitution and By-Laws of the Order. Its powers include, but are not limited to:

- (i) Granting, revoking, or suspending charters and commissions for Constituent Lodges in accordance with established rules of the Order.
- (ii) Preserving, monitoring, and authorizing the use of ceremonial work, symbols, and teachings unique to the Ancient Order of Free Gardeners.
- (iii) Enacting laws, resolutions, and decisions that bind all Lodges and members within the jurisdiction.
- (iv) Serving as the final court of appeal for all disciplinary actions, disputes, and charges originating in a constituent lodge.
- (v) Overseeing the financial affairs of their territory, including dues, assessments, and expenditures for charitable or operational purposes.
- (vi) Convening Biennial Grand Lodge Sessions, or special convocations when necessary, to deliberate on matters affecting the welfare and growth of the Order.

Section 4.03 Compliance. Grand Lodges shall remain in good standing through compliance with the constitution, resolutions, and rulings of the United Council and the laws of the state/province/territory and nation in which it operates. Grand Lodges are subject to visitation, audit, and disciplinary oversight as may be deemed necessary by the United Council.

(a) Duties and Responsibilities. Grand Lodges shall provide updated membership rosters to the United Council and forward all commission and charter requests to the same.

Section 4.04 Constituent Lodges. Constituent Lodges are duly chartered (or commissioned) and recognized self-governing branches of the Ancient Order of Free Gardeners, functioning under the authority and jurisdiction of a Grand Lodge of the same. Each Lodge serves as the local embodiment of the Order's principles, ceremonies, purpose and objectives, providing a structured space for members to meet, grow, and serve together in the spirit of unity and fraternity.

(a) Duties and Responsibilities. Each Constituent Lodge shall:

- (i) Conduct its internal affairs in accordance with its bylaws, provided they are consistent with those of the Grand Lodge and United Council.
- (ii) Uphold and perform the ceremonial work of the Order as authorized and interpreted by the United Council.
- (iii) Keep accurate records of members, meetings, degrees conferred, and financial matters, subject to periodic review by the Grand Lodge.
- (iv) Submit required fees (if there be any) and reports to the Grand Lodge in a timely manner.
- (v) Advance the moral, charitable, and educational objectives of the Ancient Order of Free Gardeners within their community.

Section 4.05 Compliance. All Constituent Lodges shall remain in good standing through compliance with the constitution, resolutions, and rulings of the Grand Lodge, so long as the same does not contradict the Constitution and By-Laws, resolutions and rulings of the United Council. Constituent Lodges are subject to visitation, audit, and disciplinary oversight as may be deemed necessary by the Grand Lodge.

Section 4.06 Independent Lodges. Independent Lodges are autonomous bodies of the Ancient Order of Free Gardeners, located in a state, province, territory or nation where no Grand Lodge has been established, that are established by direct commission or charter granted by the United Council. While each Lodge governs its own internal affairs, it remains under the general oversight and supervisory care of the United Council, to ensure compliance with the shared ideals and practices of the Order.

(a) Authority and Responsibilities. An Independent Lodge shall:

- (i) Be formed through a charter or commission issued by the United Council, which defines its recognition and affiliation with the broader fraternity.
- (ii) Operate with internal self-governance, elect its officers, manage its finances, and conduct its ceremonial work according to its own bylaws, provided they align with the Constitution and By-Laws of the Order.
- (iii) Preserve and practice the traditions of the Free Gardeners, with respect for the ceremonies and teachings prescribed by the United Council.
- (iv) Remain open to periodic review, correspondence, or visitation by the United Council, which offers advisory support and ensures the Lodge maintains the integrity of the Order.
- (v) Promote the moral, charitable, and educational objectives of the fraternity, contributing to the legacy and mission of the Order.

Section 4.07 Compliance. Independent Lodges shall remain in good standing through compliance with the constitution, resolutions, and rulings of the United Council and the laws of the state/province/territory and nation in which it operates. Independent Lodges are subject to visitation, audit, and disciplinary oversight as may be deemed necessary by the United Council.

Section 4.08 Commissions. A Commission is an official document issued by a recognized Grand Lodge or by the United Council of the Ancient Order of Free Gardeners, granting authority to a qualified Third Degree (Master Gardener) member or body of members to initiate the organization and establishment of a new Lodge within a designated area.

(a) **Authority and Scope.** A Commission conveys provisional authority to function as a Lodge-in-formation, granting all rights and privileges accorded to constituent or independent Lodges. Degree ceremonies should be reported to the proper bodies (Grand Lodge and/or United Council).

Section 4.09 Issuance and Jurisdictional Limits. Grand Lodges may issue Commissions only for prospective Lodges to be formed within their defined jurisdiction. The United Council may issue Commissions only for prospective Lodges to be formed in territories not under the jurisdiction of any existing A.O.F.G. Grand Lodge. Commissions should not be withheld for any reason other than severe violations of the rules and regulations by the individual(s) requesting said charter.

(a) **Expiration and Transition to Charter.** Commissions shall remain in force only until: The granting of an official Charter to the commissioned Lodge by the issuing body.

Section 4.10 Supervision. Lodges operating under Commission shall remain under the advisory supervision and oversight of the issuing authority, which retains the right to visit, review, and revoke said commission if deemed necessary for the good of the Order.

Section 4.11 Charters. A Charter is a permanent and formal document granted by a recognized Grand Lodge or the United Council of the Ancient Order of Free Gardeners. It authorizes a Lodge to exist as a fully constituted body of the Order, possessing full rights, privileges, and responsibilities, including the authority to confer degrees and conduct all ceremonial work in accordance with the ancient customs prescribed by the United Council.

Section 4.12 Issuance and Authority. A Charter may be granted to a body of Master Gardeners who have demonstrated readiness and harmony while operating under a valid Commission, or by direct petition where no Commission was previously issued. The granting authority must be: a Grand Lodge, for Lodges situated within its defined jurisdiction; or The United Council, for Lodges established in regions beyond the jurisdiction of any recognized Grand Lodge. Charters should not be withheld for any reason other than severe violations of the rules and regulations by the individuals requesting said charter.

(a) **Rights Conferred.** Upon receipt of a Charter, the Lodge becomes a permanent and recognized part of the Order, and is thereby empowered to:

- (i) Confer all authorized degrees of the Ancient Order of Free Gardeners.
- (ii) Elect and install its officers.
- (iii) Adopt bylaws governing its internal affairs (subject to approval by the issuing authority, where applicable).
- (iv) Conduct ceremonies, meetings, and charitable works in the name of the Order.
- (v) Maintain fraternal relations with other Chartered Lodges and recognized Gardeners' bodies, as permitted.

(b) Custody and Revocation. The Charter shall remain in the custody of the Lodge and be displayed at all regular meetings. It may be revoked, suspended, or surrendered only by the authority that issued it, in cases of irregular conduct, severe violation of the Order's principles, rules and regulations, or dissolution of the Lodge by due process.

ARTICLE V: ADMINISTRATIVE AUTHORITY

Section 5.01 The United Council shall have the administrative authority to:

- (a) establish, regulate and control the Ceremonial, Lecture, and Secret Works of the Order, and the distribution of the same.
- (b) To prescribe the standard for all membership cards, certificates, ceremonies, jewels and regalia, and provide Authorized Certificates designating a company as an official vendor of the Order.
- (c) To prescribe minimum qualifications for membership in the Order.
- (d) To grant commissions for the formation of Grand Lodges and Independent Lodges under the direct supervision of the United Council.
- (e) To grant charters to Grand Lodges and Independent Lodges under the direct supervision of the United Council.
- (f) To oversee the internal investigation and tribunals of the Order when requested by a Grand Lodge, Independent Lodge or Constituent Lodge; and deliver an appropriate resolution or verdict at the conclusion of the same.

ARTICLE VI: UNITED COUNCIL: AUTHORITY AND ELECTIONS

Section 6.01 Council Powers and Number. The affairs and property of the United Council shall be managed by or under the direction of the Board of Director (the “Directors”, “Director Members”) with the assistance of an appropriate committee, subject to applicable law and in accordance with the purposes and limitations set forth in the Certificate of Incorporation and herein. The number of Board members shall be at least three (3). Within the specified limits, the number of directors can be increased or decreased from time to time, by resolution of the Council, but such action by the Council shall require a majority vote from the Entire Council. As used in these by-laws, the term “Entire Council” shall mean the total number of directors entitled to vote.

Section 6.02 Election and Term of Office. The initial directors shall be the persons named in the Certificate of Incorporation and shall serve until the first Grand Assembly of the Ancient Order of Free Gardeners. Thereafter, to become a director, a person shall be nominated by any member in good standing and elected at a Grand Assembly by majority vote of the members present. Directors shall hold office for a term of three (3) years, and each shall serve for such term and until the election and installation of a successor, or until such director's death, resignation, or removal. Directors may be elected for three consecutive terms or three non-consecutive terms.

Section 6.03 Qualifications for Directorship. Each director must be a Past Master (fourth (4th) degree member) and shall be at least 21 years of age. The Council may set such other qualifications for directors as it deems necessary or appropriate, in its good faith discretion. Any director must be an active member of the Ancient Order of Free Gardeners and should a fail to remain in good standing with their local lodge, he shall be immediately removed as a director and shall no longer be a Director Member.

Section 6.04 Vacancies. Vacancies occurring for any reason, including any vacancy occurring by reason of the death, resignation, or removal of a director, may be filled at any meeting of the Council by the vote of the majority of the directors then in office, although less than a quorum, or by a sole remaining director. Each director so elected shall serve until the next Grand Assembly of the Order or until such director's successor is elected or appointed.

Section 6.05 Removal. Any director may be removed at any time by a vote of a majority of the United Council or during a Special Assembly by request of a significant number of members of the Order.

Section 6.06 Resignation. Any director may resign from the Council at any time by giving prior written notice to the Council. Unless otherwise specified in the notice, the resignation shall take effect at the time of receipt by the Council. The acceptance of such resignation shall not be necessary to make it effective. No resignations shall discharge any accrued obligation or duty of a director. As set forth above, resignation as a director shall terminate the former director’s Director Member status.

Section 6.07 Meetings. The Assembly meeting and regular quarterly meetings of the Council shall be held at such times and places as may from time to time be fixed by the Council

or may be specified in the notice of meeting. Special meetings of the Council or Assembly may be held at any time upon the call of the Chairman or as determined by the Council in each case at such time and place as shall be fixed by the person or persons calling the meeting, as specified in the notice thereof.

Section 6.08 Notice of Meetings. Notice of a meeting shall be sent by mail, and electronic mail or hand delivery, directed to each director at his address or contact information as it appears on the records of the Council. Such notice shall state the time and place where the meeting is to be held and to the extent possible, the purpose(s) for which the meeting is called. Notice shall be deemed to have been given when sent (electronically), and if by mail, when deposited with prepaid postage thereon. Notice of any regular meeting for which the time and place is not fixed by the Council must be given to each director not less than five (5) days before such meeting. Notice of a special meeting of the Council must be given to each director not less than five (5) days before such meeting, provided, however, that notice of special meetings to discuss matters requiring prompt action may be given no less than forty-eight hours before the time at which such meeting is to be held if given personally, by telephone, by facsimile transmission or by electronic mail, unless the meeting relates to an emergency which must be resolved within forty-eight hours, in which case notice shall be given as promptly as possible. Notice of a regular or special meeting need not be given to a director who submits a signed waiver of notice before or at the meeting's commencement, or who attends the meeting without protesting (not later than the commencement of the meeting) the lack of notice to him or her.

Section 6.09 Quorum. At each meeting of the Council, the presence of a majority of the Entire Council shall constitute a quorum for the transaction of business or any specified item of business. If a quorum is not present at any meeting of the Council, a majority of the directors present may adjourn the meeting to another time without notice other than by announcement at the meeting, until such a quorum is present, except that notice of such adjournment shall be given to any directors who were not present at the time of the adjournment. At a special assembly meeting of the Order, the presence of a majority of the Entire Council and at minimum of seven (7) general members in good standing shall constitute a quorum for the transaction of business or any specified item of business.

Section 6.10 Voting. Except as otherwise provided by statute or these by-laws, the vote of a majority of the directors present at the time of a vote, if a quorum is present at such time, shall be the act of the Council. Likewise, the vote of a majority of the members present at the time of a vote during triennial assembly meetings and special assembly meetings, if a quorum is present at such time, shall be the act of the Council. If a Director Member shall not vote on any business that involves his proposed removal from the Council.

Section 6.11 Meeting by Remote Communication. Any one or more members of the Council or any committee thereof may participate in a meeting of the Council or such committee by means of a conference telephone, video conference, internet-based meeting forum, or similar communications equipment. Participation by such means shall constitute presence in person at a meeting provided that all persons participating in the meeting can hear each other at the same time and each director can participate in all matters before the Council, including, without limitation, the ability to propose, object to, and vote upon a specific action to be taken by the

Council or committee. The appropriate audio and video equipment shall be provided to ensure members attending virtually and in person are able to see and hear anyone who has the floor during the meeting.

Section 6.12 Action without a Meeting. Any action required or permitted to be taken by the Council or any committee thereof may be taken without a meeting if all members of the Council or committee consent in writing to the adoption of a resolution authorizing the action. Such consent may be written or electronic. The resolution and written consents thereto by the members of the Council or such committee shall be filed with the minutes of the proceedings of the Council or such committee.

Section 6.13 Director Compensation. Generally, the Order shall not pay compensation to directors for services rendered to the Order in their capacity as directors, except that directors may be reimbursed for reasonable expenses incurred in the performance of their duties to the Order.

ARTICLE VII: COMMITTEES

Section 7.01 Committees of the Council. The committees of the United Council shall include standing (permanent) and special (temporary). The Council, by resolution adopted by a majority of the Entire Council, may establish new standing committees based on the needs of the Order. Committees shall consist of at least three (3) members who have received the Past Master's degree of the Order. The following standing committees shall be perpetual and may never be dissolved: Ceremonial Standards, Growth and Expansion, Ethics Committee, Preservation and Instruction, Public Relations and Communications, and Financial Oversight. Each committee of the Council shall have such authority as the Council shall by resolution provide; except that no such committee shall have the ability to decide on matters to be addressed by the Entire Council or Entire Membership (Assembly) but may submit recommendations as committee when called to do so by the Council or by virtue of the committee's designated duties. Ideal committee appointments are based on the experience and skills of the appointee.

Section 7.02 Quorum and Action by Committee. Unless otherwise provided by resolution of the Council, a three (3) or more members shall constitute a quorum for the transaction of business and the vote of a majority of the committee. The procedures of the committees of the Council shall be subject at all times to the directions of the Council and in agreement with the bylaws of the United Council and the Constitution and Bylaws of the Order.

Section 7.03 Alternate Members. The Council may designate one (1) or more directors as alternate members of any committee, who may replace any absent or disqualified member or members at any meeting of such committee.

Section 7.04 Committee Officers. Committees of the Council shall include an executive board consisting of a Committee Chair, Vice-Chair and Secretary.

Section 7.05 Duties of Committees. The duties of the standing committees of the Council are as follows:

A. Ceremonial Standards Committee

- Preserves and promotes the correct use of ceremonial traditions.
- Provides guidance on initiation rites and ritual accuracy.
- Monitors adherence to ceremonial practices across grand lodges and independent lodges.

B. Growth and Expansion Committee

- Develops strategies for membership recruitment and retention.
- Coordinates efforts for establishing new lodges.
- Reviews requests for commissions and grants charters to grand lodges and independent lodges (lodges in a state, province or territory without an established grand lodge)

C. Ethics Committee

- Ensures adherence to ethical principles and integrity within the order.
- Advises on policy matters affecting lodges while respecting autonomy.
- Acts as a mediator in disputes between lodges when requested.

D. Preservation and Instruction Committee

- Maintains historical archives and promotes research into the order's origins.
- Organizes educational programs and public outreach.
- Oversees initiatives to document and share the order's traditions.

E. Public Relations and Communication Committee

- Manages external communications, branding, and public awareness efforts.
- Oversees digital platforms, including websites and social media presence.
- Coordinates promotional and outreach initiatives.

F. Financial Oversight Committee

- Ensures financial transparency within the council.
- Develops fundraising programs to support council initiatives.
- Advises lodges on sustainable financial practices.

ARTICLE VIII: DIRECTORS, EMPLOYEES, AND AGENTS

Section 8.01 Directors. The directors of the Order shall consist of a Chairman, Vice-Chairman, Secretary-General, Treasurer and Archivist. All directors shall be elected by the Assembly from slates of eligible candidates, the composition of which is determined by the nominations from. Any member in good standing who has received the Past Master's Degree may nominate themselves or any eligible member for directorship.

Section 8.02 Election, Term of Office, and Qualifications. The directors of the Order shall be elected triennially by a majority vote of the Entire Membership present at the assembly

meeting of the Grand Assembly, except in other instances specified in these bylaws. Each director shall hold office until such director's successor is elected and or until such director's earlier death, resignation, or removal. No person may hold and perform the duties of more than one director position. All directors shall be subject to the supervision and direction of the Entire Council. The Council may set such qualification requirements for officers as it deems appropriate by resolution to be voted on by the Assembly.

Section 8.03 Removal. Any director elected by the assembly may be removed at any time, in accordance with the procedures outlined in these bylaws.

Section 8.04 Resignations. Any director may resign at any time by giving at least ten (10) days' written notice to the Council. Unless otherwise specified in the notice, the resignation shall take effect at the time of receipt by the Council. The acceptance of such resignation shall not be necessary to make it effective.

Section 8.05 Vacancies. A vacancy in any office arising from any cause shall be filled for the unexpired portion of the term by the Council.

Section 8.06 Chairman. The Chairman shall preside at all meetings of the Council and Assembly, ensuring order and harmony are maintained. He shall have the general powers and duties of supervision and management of the Council which usually pertain to his office and shall keep the Order fully informed of the activities of the Council. The Chairman shall perform all such other duties as are properly required of him by the Council and the bylaws. He has the power to sign and execute in the name of the Order all contracts authorized either generally or specifically by the Council, unless the Council specifically requires an additional signature.

Section 8.07 Vice Chairman. The Vice Chairman shall support the Chairman in his duties, and in the absence of the Chairman, perform the duties and exercise the powers of the Chairman. The Vice Chairman shall have such powers and perform such duties as usually pertain to his office or as are properly required of him by the Council.

Section 8.08 Secretary-General. The Secretary-General shall record and keep accurate minutes of all meetings of the Council and the Assembly in books or electronic documents kept for that purpose, and ensure copies of all approved minutes are provided electronically to the grand lodges and independent lodges of the Order. He shall see that all notices and reports are given and served as required by law or these bylaws. He shall receive and distribute all correspondence on behalf of the Council in a timely manner. He shall affix the corporate seal ("the seal") to and sign such documents that require the seal and his signature and shall perform all duties as usually pertain to his office or as are properly required of him or her by the Council.

Section 8.09 Treasurer. The Treasurer shall have the care and custody of all the funds and securities of the Order and shall keep full and accurate accounts of all money received and paid by him on behalf of the Order. The Treasurer shall exhibit at all reasonable times the Order's books of accounts and records to any of the directors of the Order upon request and shall provide copies of the same to the Secretary-General quarterly for distribution to Entire Membership of the Order. He shall render a detailed statement to the Council of the condition of the finances of

the Order at the Grand Assembly of the Assembly and shall perform such other duties as usually pertain to his office or as are properly required of him by the Council. He shall also work with the Financial Oversight Committee to craft an annual budget for the Council.

Section 8.10 Archivist. The Archivist shall ensure the preservation of all historical records, ceremonies, and traditions of the Order. He shall work with the Preservation and Instruction Committee to ensure that the integrity of the ceremonies is maintained during revisions and regular use, and that instruction materials are provided to the grand lodges and independent lodges of the Order.

Section 8.11 Employees and Other Agents. The Council may from time to time appoint such employees and other agents as it shall deem necessary, each of whom shall have such authority and perform such duties as the Council may from time to time determine.

Section 8.12 Compensation. Any employee, or agent of the Order is authorized to receive a reasonable compensation for services rendered to the Order when authorized by a majority of the Entire Board, in its discretion and/or designated in the budget.

ARTICLE IX: AMENDMENTS

Section 9.01 These bylaws may be altered, amended, or repealed by the affirmative vote of the majority of the Entire Membership present at any meeting of the Assembly at which a quorum is present. Such action is authorized only at a duly called and held meeting of the Council or Assembly for which written notice of such meeting, setting forth the proposed alteration, is given in accordance with the notice provisions for special meetings set forth herein. If these by-laws are altered, amended, or repealed, there shall be due notice given to the Entire Membership in a timely manner of the bylaws so adopted, amended, or repealed, together with a concise statement of the changes made.

ARTICLE X: NON-DISCRIMINATION

Section 10.01 In all of its dealings, neither the Order nor its duly authorized directors, members, grand lodges, lodges, employees or agents shall discriminate against any individual or group for reasons of race, color, creed, sex, age, culture, national origin, marital status, sexual preference, mental or physical handicap, or any category protected by state or federal law.

ARTICLE XI: REFERENCE TO CERTIFICATE OF INCORPORATION

Section 11.01 References in these bylaws to the Certificate of Incorporation shall include all amendments thereto or changes thereof as of the relevant time unless specifically otherwise stated by these bylaws. In the event of a conflict between the Certificate of Incorporation and these bylaws, the Certificate of Incorporation shall supersede the bylaws.

ARTICLE XII: GENERAL PROVISIONS

Section 12.01 Fiscal Year. The fiscal year of the Order shall be the calendar year unless otherwise provided by the Council (January 1st – December 31st).

Section 12.02 Seal. The Council is required to have a corporate seal. The corporate seal shall have inscribed thereon the name of the Order, the year of its organization, and such other terms as are required. The seal may be used by embossing it or a facsimile thereof to be impressed or affixed or in any manner reproduced by the Secretary-General.

(a) Grand Lodges and Independent Lodges shall be required to have an official seal which shall include the name of the Grand Lodge or Lodge, the year of its organization and the name of the Order (“The Ancient Order of Free Gardeners, Inc.”). This shall be in the care of the Worthy Grand Secretary of said Grand Lodge or the Secretary or Said Lodge.

Section 12.03 Books and Records. The Council shall keep at the office of the Order correct and complete books and records of the activities and transactions of the Council, including the minute book (s), which shall contain a copy of the Certificate of Incorporation, a copy of these bylaws and all prior versions thereof (if and as applicable), all resolutions and written consents of the Council, and all minutes of meetings of the Assembly and meetings of the Council and committees thereof.

Section 12.04 Records Retention and Destruction Policy. The Order may adopt such record-keeping policies and procedures as necessary for its business, regulatory, and tax-exempt status.

Section 12.05 Annual Returns; Necessary Filings. The Entire Council shall review the Council’s annual filing(s) with the Internal Revenue Service prior to it being filed. The Council may delegate to one or more Directors, in addition to the Financial Oversight Committee, the preparation of filings and reports related to the Order’s tax-exempt status or any other matter, subject to the Council’s oversight, and may employ consultants or advisers, including legal or tax counsel, in connection with the preparation and/or review of such material(s).

Section 12.06 Electronic Signatures. Wherever a written instrument is required to be executed hereunder, an electronic signature, to the extent permitted by applicable law, shall be deemed to be a written signature.

CHAPTER II: GRAND LODGES OF THE ANCIENT ORDER OF FREE GARDNERS

ARTICLE I: NAME AND OPERATION

Section 1.01 Name. The official name, style, and title of a Grand Lodge shall be: “Ancient Order of Free Gardeners (A.O.F.G.), [Jurisdiction] Grand Lodge,” and shall henceforth be governed by the following regulations.

Section 1.02 Organization. Grand Lodges shall be established or reorganized in accordance with the provisions of this chapter. To more effectively fulfill their organizational purposes—particularly concerning the management of property entrusted to them—they are hereby authorized, as soon as practicable after their formation, to obtain corporate charters from the appropriate governmental authorities of the State, District, Territory, Province, or Nation in which they are located. These charters shall grant them legal status as corporate entities, empowering them to acquire, hold title to, and, if necessary, pursue legal action to recover such funds and property as fall within their jurisdiction.

Section 1.03 Purpose. To exercise general oversight of the Ancient Order of Free Gardeners within its jurisdiction, with the aim of fostering the growth, harmony, and well-being of its Constituent lodges and their members.

Section 1.04 Objectives. To uphold and advance the principles of Love, Wisdom, Harmony, and Truth; and to cultivate an environment where seekers and Free Gardeners are encouraged to embark on a path of self-discovery and enlightenment, promoting their intellectual, moral, social, and spiritual growth; to promote programs and events which foster the stewardship of nature and the intellectual, moral, social and spiritual wellbeing of mankind.

Section 1.05 Interest of the United Council. The United Council of the Ancient Order of Free Gardeners shall retain a reversionary interest in all property, funds, ceremonial materials, and official records held by Grand Lodges and Independent Lodges. In the event of the voluntary or involuntary dissolution of a Grand Lodge, such assets shall be surrendered to the Council within thirty (30) days of the effective date of dissolution.

Section 1.06 Authority. Grand Lodges shall have autonomy and exclusive authority over all concerns of the Order within its jurisdiction. Each Grand lodge shall adopt bylaws, using the prescribed template provided by the United Council, to govern their jurisdiction. Grand Lodges shall have the authority to add sections to the prescribed by-laws template for the benefit of its jurisdiction. Grand Lodge bylaws must not contradict the Constitution and By-Laws of the Ancient Order of Free Gardeners.

Section 1.07 Non-Interference Policy. The United Council shall not intervene in the internal affairs of any Grand Lodge, Independent Lodge, or Constituent Lodge unless such involvement is specifically requested or deemed essential for the protection and welfare of the Order and its members. Similarly, Grand Lodges shall not involve themselves in the business operations of Constituent Lodges within their jurisdiction, except when their assistance is

requested or determined necessary for the Order's well-being. No Grand Lodge may interfere in the affairs of another Grand Lodge or any Constituent or Independent Lodge outside its designated jurisdiction, unless expressly authorized by the United Council to assist in the formation or reorganization of said lodge.

Section 1.08 Charters and Commissions. A Grand Lodge may be established or restructured upon submission of a formal petition for charter by at least five (5) Independent Lodges. Collectively, these lodges must include a minimum of four (4) individuals who have attained the rank of Past Master Gardener and be located within the same State, Province, Nation, or Territory. Only one Grand Lodge may be chartered per geographic region—no more than one may exist within the same State, Province, Nation, or Territory. If the petitioning lodges do not meet the requirement of four (4) Past Master Gardeners, they may be granted a provisional commission. This commission will remain in effect until the required number of eligible Master Gardeners has earned the Past Master's Degree. A quorum of at least four (4) Past Master Gardeners is required to vote on applications for Constituent lodge charters or commissions. Grand Lodges operating under a commission are not authorized to issue charters or commissions for Constituent lodges. All such applications must be submitted to and approved by the United Council until the Grand Lodge obtains an official charter or receives a special warrant authorizing such actions. Commissioned Grand Lodges must also maintain a quorum of at least four (4) Master Gardeners for operational proceedings.

Section 1.09 Headquarters. The official headquarters of the Grand Lodge, including the office of the Worthy Grand Secretary, shall be located at a site designated by the Grand Lodge, in accordance with its By-Laws.

ARTICLE II: GRAND LODGE OFFICERS

Section 2.01 Qualifications of Grand Lodge Officers. All Grand Lodge officers shall be duly elected or appointed members who have attained the Past Master's Degree. Master Gardeners may be appointed to serve on a Grand Lodge committee, except where otherwise specified in the Grand Lodge By-Laws

Section 2.02 Elected Officers. Elected officers of the Grand Lodge shall be qualified members chosen from regularly chartered lodges within its jurisdiction. The elected positions shall include: Most Worthy Grand Master; Most Worthy Grand Emissary Master; Most Worthy Grand Secretary; Most Worthy Grand Rentmaster; Most Worthy Grand Instruction Master.

Section 2.03 Appointed Officers. Appointed officers of the Grand Lodge shall be qualified members chosen from regularly chartered lodges within its jurisdiction. The appointed positions shall include: Right Worthy Grand Chaplain; Right Worthy Grand Gatekeeper; Right Worthy Grand Keyholder.

Section 2.04 Term of Grand Lodge Officers. Elected and appointed Grand Lodge officers shall serve for a term of two (2) years. No one may serve as Grand Master or Grand Emissary Master for more than two consecutive terms.

Section 2.05 Most Worthy Grand Master. The duties of the Most Worthy Grand Master shall be to: Preside over all Grand Lodge meetings, ensuring order, peace, and harmony throughout the proceedings; Serve as the highest-ranking Officer of the Order within his jurisdiction; Inspire members to contribute meaningfully to the Order and the broader community; Issue Commissions and Grant Charters to qualified petitioners; Ensure that the operations of the Grand Lodge and its Constituent Lodges align with the Grand Lodge By-Laws, the Constitution and By-Laws of the Order, and all applicable national, state, provincial, or territorial laws and regulations; Appoint officers to serve during his term; Select committee chairs to lead both standing and special committees; Fulfill any additional responsibilities as outlined by the Constitution and By-Laws of the Order.

Section 2.06 Most Worthy Grand Emissary Master. The duties of the Most Worthy Grand Emissary Master shall be to: Assist the Most Worthy Grand Master in the execution of his duties and preside in his place in the event of his absence or removal; Represent the Most Worthy Grand Master during lodge visitations and public engagements, when called upon; Serve as the public representative of the Grand Lodge when meeting with other organizations or entities; Carry out any other duties as assigned by the Most Worthy Grand Master or as directed by the Constitution and By-Laws of the Order.

Section 2.07 Most Worthy Grand Secretary. The duties of the Most Worthy Grand Secretary shall be to: Oversee all official communications of the Grand Lodge, ensuring their receipt and proper distribution; Develop and maintain an operations manual that outlines the procedures essential to the daily functioning of the Grand Lodge; Prepares agendas for the regular (quarterly) meetings in collaboration with the Most Worthy Grand Master; Appoint, with the approval of the Most Worthy Grand Master, an Assistant to support him in clerical responsibilities; Keep accurate records of all Grand Lodge proceedings; Manage the collection and dissemination of annual reports from Constituent Lodges; Receive quarterly reports from Grand Lodge Committees; Perform any other duties as assigned by the Most Worthy Grand Master or as directed by the Constitution and By-Laws of the Order.

Section 2.08 Most Worthy Grand Rentmaster. The duties of the Most Worthy Grand Rentmaster shall be to: Receive, safeguard, and disburse all funds belonging to the Grand Lodge; Maintain accurate and up-to-date financial records, including ledgers, statements, and reports; preparing and presenting periodic (quarterly) financial statements to the Grand Lodge at its regular meetings or upon request; Ensure that all expenditures are made in accordance with approved budgets and financial policies; Coordinate with the Financial Oversight Committee on matters relating to financial planning, audits, and fundraisers; Assist Constituent Lodges with financial compliance and reporting as needed; Perform any other financial duties as may be assigned by the Most Worthy Grand Master or as directed by the Constitution and By-Laws of the Order.

Section 2.09 Most Worthy Grand Instruction Master. The duties of the Most Worthy Grand Instruction Master shall be to: Promote uniformity and accuracy in ceremonial practices and ceremonial work across the jurisdiction; Provide instruction and guidance to Constituent Lodges on proper procedures, ensuring adherence to the traditions, ceremonies, and established protocols of the Order; Conduct educational sessions, training workshops, and demonstrations to enhance the knowledge and proficiency of Grand Lodge officers and

Constituent Lodge officers and members; serves as chair of the Ceremonial Standards Committee; Assist in the development of instructional materials and supports the overall mission of the Grand Lodge by fostering excellence in ceremonial work and decorum; Perform any other duties as assigned by the Most Worthy Grand Master or as directed by the Constitution and By-Laws of the Order.

Section 2.10 Right Worthy Grand Chaplain. The duties of the Right Worthy Grand Chaplain shall be to: Provide spiritual and moral support and guidance to the members of the Grand Lodge; Foster a sense of unity, compassion, and moral integrity; Offer invocations, benedictions, and other appropriate prayers or reflections at official gatherings, ceremonies, and special observances; Support members during times of personal hardship, illness, or bereavement by extending words of comfort and encouragement on behalf of the Grand Lodge; Ensures that the spiritual traditions and moral values of the Order are upheld and reflected in its activities; Coordinate memorial services and assist in promoting charitable efforts consistent with the Order's mission, when called upon to do so; Perform any other duties as assigned by the Most Worthy Grand Master or as directed by the Constitution and By-Laws of the Order.

Section 2.11 Right Worthy Grand Gatekeeper. The duties of the Right Worthy Grand Gatekeeper shall be to: Guard the outer gate (door) of the entrance to the Grand Lodge when in session and maintain the integrity and security of the same; Ensure that only qualified members are admitted and that the ceremonial environment is preserved without interruption; direct members and guests as they enter and leave the Grand Lodge when in session; Perform any other duties as assigned by the Most Worthy Grand Master or as directed by the Constitution and By-Laws of the Order.

Section 2.12 Right Worthy Grand Keyholder. Guard the inner gate (door) of the entrance to the Grand Lodge when in session and maintain the integrity and security of the same; Escort dignitaries, introduce visitors, and direct the physical arrangement of officers and regalia during closed or public ceremonies; Aid in maintaining decorum throughout all official functions, in accordance with the traditions and ceremonial standards of the Order; Perform any other duties as assigned by the Most Worthy Grand Master or as directed by the Constitution and By-Laws of the Order.

Section 2.13 Grand Lodge Committees. The Grand Lodge Committees shall include standing (permanent) and special (temporary). The Grand Lodge, by resolution adopted by a majority vote of the Grand Lodge Officers, may establish new standing committees based on the needs of the Order. Committees shall consist of at least three (3) members who have received the Master Gardener's degree of the Order. The following standing committees shall be perpetual and may never be dissolved: Ceremonial Standards, Growth and Expansion, Ethics Committee, Preservation and Instruction, Public Relations and Communications, and Financial Oversight. Each committee shall have such authority as the Grand Lodge shall by resolution provide; except that no such committee shall have the ability to decide on matters to be addressed by the Entire Body (Grand Lodge officers) but may submit recommendations as committee when called to do so by the Most Worthy Grand Master or by virtue of the committee's designated duties. Ideal committee appointments are based on the experience and skills of the appointee.

Section 2.14 Quorum and Action by Committee. Unless otherwise provided by resolution of the Grand Lodge, three (3) or more members shall constitute a quorum for the transaction of business and the vote of a majority of a committee. The Committee Secretary in collaboration with the Committee Chair shall create and distribute a meeting agenda to accompany an official notice to all members of the Grand Lodge thirty (30) days before the date of the meeting, with a reminder seven (7) days before the date. The procedures of the committees shall be subject at all times to the directions of the Most Worthy Grand Master and in agreement with the bylaws of Grand Lodge and the Constitution and Bylaws of the Order.

Section 2.15 Alternate Members. The Most Worthy Grand Master may designate one (1) or more Grand Lodge officers as alternate members of any committee, who may replace any absent or disqualified member or members at any meeting of such committee.

Section 2.16 Grand Lodge Committee Officers. Committees shall include an executive board consisting of a Committee Chair, Vice-Chair and Secretary.

Section 2.17 Duties of Committees. The duties of the standing Grand Lodge committees are as follows:

(a) Ceremonial Standards Committee

- Preserves and promotes the correct use of ceremonial traditions.
- Provides guidance on initiation rites and ceremonial accuracy.
- Monitors adherence to ceremonial practices across grand lodges and independent lodges.

(b) Growth and Expansion Committee

- Develops strategies for membership recruitment and retention.
- Coordinates efforts for establishing new lodges.
- Reviews requests for commissions and grants charters to grand lodges and independent lodges (lodges in a state, province or territory without an established grand lodge)

(c) Ethics Committee

- Ensures adherence to ethical principles and integrity within the order.
- Advises on policy matters affecting lodges while respecting autonomy.
- Acts as a mediator in disputes between lodges when requested.

(d) Preservation and Instruction Committee

- Maintains historical archives and promotes research into the order's origins.
- Organizes educational programs and public outreach.
- Oversees initiatives to document and share the order's traditions.

(e) Public Relations and Communication Committee

- Manages external communications, branding, and public awareness efforts in accordance with the Brand Standard prescribed by the United Council.
- Oversees digital platforms, including websites and social media presence.
- Coordinates promotional and outreach initiatives.

(f) Financial Oversight Committee

- Ensures financial transparency within the council.
- Develops fundraising programs to support council initiatives.
- Advises lodges sustainable financial practices.

ARTICLE III: GRAND LODGE MEETINGS

Section 3.01 Regular Meetings. The Grand Lodge shall convene in regular session once each quarter, with meetings to be held during the months of March, June, September, and December (this does not include the January Planning Meeting). The specific date, time, and location of each quarterly meeting shall be determined by the Most Worthy Grand Master and communicated to all members no less than thirty (30) days in advance.

(a) Annual Planning Meeting. An Annual Planning Meeting of the Grand Lodge shall be held each January, on a date set by the Most Worthy Grand Master, for the primary purpose of establishing the preliminary itinerary and strategic objectives for the forthcoming calendar year.

(i) Participants. This meeting shall include the elected and appointed Grand Lodge officers, committee chairs, and any other individuals designated by the Most Worthy Grand Master whose input is deemed essential to the planning process.

(ii) Agenda and Preparation. The agenda for the Annual Planning Meeting shall include, but not be limited to: review of the previous year's activities, scheduling of ceremonial and administrative events, setting of key deadlines for reports and initiatives, alignment of committee objectives, and discussion of resource needs. All officers and committee chairs shall be required to submit a summary of proposed goals or activities in advance of the meeting, as directed by the Grand Secretary.

(iii) Reporting and Implementation. Outcomes of the Annual Planning Meeting shall be documented and circulated by the Grand Secretary within ten (10) business days. The finalized itinerary and strategic plan shall serve as a foundational guide for the activities and obligations of the Grand Lodge throughout the year, subject to amendment by vote at a regular quarterly meeting, if necessary.

Section 3.02 Purpose. Regular quarterly meetings shall be held to conduct the official business of the Grand Lodge, including but not limited to the reception of reports from officers and committees, review of financial statements, consideration of petitions and correspondence, planning of upcoming events, and the discussion and adoption of matters essential to the welfare of the Order.

Section 3.03 Quorum. A quorum for the transaction of business at any regular quarterly meeting shall consist of a majority of the elected officers of the Grand Lodge and duly credentialed representatives from a majority of the Constituent Lodges within the jurisdiction.

Section 3.04 Notice and Agenda. The Grand Secretary shall issue formal notice of each quarterly meeting, including a proposed agenda and relevant documentation, to all officers and Lodges not less than thirty (30) days prior to the meeting date.

Section 3.05 Committee Meetings. *[see Article II, Sections 13&14]*

ARTICLE IV: Biennial Grand Session

Section 4.01 Grand Lodge Session. The Biennial Grand Session shall serve as the highest legislative and ceremonial gathering of the Grand Lodge, convened to conduct major business of the Order, enact legislation, review jurisdictional progress, elect Grand Lodge officers, and celebrate the heritage and achievements of the Order.

Section 4.02 Timing and Location. The Biennial Grand Session shall be held every two years, during the month and at the location designated by the Most Worthy Grand Master. The date and venue shall be announced no less than six (6) months in advance to allow adequate time for preparation by Constituent Lodges and Grand Lodge committees. The Session must be located within the jurisdiction of the Grand Lodge.

Section 4.03 Delegation and Representation. Each Constituent Lodge in good standing shall be entitled to representation at the Biennial Grand Session, according to rules of delegate apportionment as prescribed by the Constitution or determined by the Grand Lodge. All elected and appointed officers of the Grand Lodge shall attend and participate in the Session.

Section 4.04 Agenda and Proceedings. The business of the Biennial Grand Session shall include, but not be limited to: officer elections, committee reports, consideration of proposed amendments to the Constitution and By-Laws, financial review, ceremonial presentations, and recognition of service and achievement. Additional activities may be scheduled in support of fellowship, education, and public engagement as approved by the Session Committee.

Section 4.05 Rules of Order. All proceedings of the Biennial Grand Session shall be conducted in accordance with the parliamentary authority adopted by the Grand Lodge, except where otherwise provided by the Constitution or these By-Laws.

Section 4.06 Biennial Grand Session Planning Committee. A Biennial Grand Session Planning Committee shall be established by the Most Worthy Grand Master no less than twelve (12) months prior to each Biennial Grand Session. Its primary purpose is to oversee and coordinate all logistical, ceremonial, and administrative preparations necessary for the successful execution of the Biennial Grand Session.

(a) Composition. The Committee shall be composed of members appointed by the Most Worthy Grand Master, including at least one elected Grand Lodge officer, one representative from the host jurisdiction (if applicable), and additional members whose expertise supports the planning objectives. The Chair of the Committee shall be designated by the Most Worthy Grand Master.

(b) Duties and Responsibilities. The Biennial Grand Session Planning Committee shall be responsible for:

- (i) Securing and coordinating the venue, lodging, and transportation arrangements for the Session;
- (ii) Developing the overall schedule of events, including ceremonial programs, business meetings, workshops, and social engagements;
- (iii) Collaborating with officers, committees, and vendors to ensure proper provision of equipment, regalia, printed materials, and other session needs;
- (iv) Managing registration processes for members, guests, and dignitaries;
- (v) Ensuring that ceremonial protocols and traditions of the Order are upheld in all scheduled proceedings;
- (vi) Preparing and distributing informational materials related to the Session, including official announcements, agendas, and guidance for attendees;
- (vii) Submitting periodic progress reports to the Most Worthy Grand Master and the Grand Lodge Executive Committee;
- (viii) Performing any additional duties as may be assigned by the Most Worthy Grand Master;
- (ix) Work closely with the Public Relations and Communication Committee for all marketing material (print and electronic); Financial Oversight Committee for all financial transactions pertaining to the Session; Ceremonial Standards Committee to ensure the proper planning and performance of ceremonial work during the session.

(c) Authority and Accountability. The Committee shall function under the direction of the Most Worthy Grand Master and shall operate within the budgetary limits approved by the Grand Lodge. All contractual obligations entered on behalf of the Session must receive prior approval from the Most Worthy Grand Master or his designated representative.

Section 4.07 Dates. To promote broad participation and minimize scheduling conflicts, the Biennial Grand Session shall be held during a weekend within the summer months, specifically between June and August. This scheduling is intended to accommodate the availability of members, delegates, and guests, and to encourage the fullest possible engagement in the proceedings of the Grand Lodge. The exact dates shall be determined and announced by the Most Worthy Grand Master in accordance with the advance notice requirements set forth in these By-Laws.

Section 4.08 Registration Process. All delegates, members, and guests intending to attend a Grand Lodge Session must complete the official registration process prior to the session. Registration may be completed in one of the following ways:

- (a) **Online Registration.** Through the designated Grand Lodge registration portal or official website.
- (b) **Mail-In Registration.** By submitting a completed registration form to the Grand Secretary at the official mailing address of the Grand Lodge.
- (c) **In-Person Registration.** Limited in-person registration may be available on-site prior to the opening of the Session, subject to an additional administrative fee and space availability.

Section 4.09 Payment Methods. Registration fees shall accompany each registration form and may be paid using one of the following methods:

- (a) **Credit or Debit Card.** For online and in-person registrations, processed through a secure payment system designated by the Grand Lodge.
- (b) **Check or Money Order:** Made payable to the Grand Lodge and submitted with the mail-in registration form.
- (c) **Electronic Transfer.** If authorized by the Grand Treasurer, registrants may pay via approved digital payment platforms or bank transfer.

Section 4.10 Time Frames and Deadlines. Early registration shall open six (6) months prior to the start of the Session and close no later than three (3) months before the Session's commencement. Late registration shall begin once Early Registration has ended, and shall close thirty (30) days before the date of the Session. Registrations received after the closing date may be subject to a late fee and are not guaranteed full access to all scheduled events, materials, or accommodations.

Section 4.11 Confirmation and Credentials. Upon successful completion and processing of registration and payment, each registrant shall receive a confirmation notice and applicable Session credentials. These credentials must be presented upon arrival to gain access to Session activities.

Section 4.12 Refunds and Transfers. Requests for refunds or transfer of registration must be submitted in writing to the Grand Secretary no later than fifteen (15) days prior to the Session. Refunds are subject to a processing fee, and no refunds will be issued after the deadline.

Section 4.13 Resolutions and Amendments. Proposed resolutions and amendments to the Constitution or By-Laws may be submitted by any Constituent Lodge in good standing, or by any member in good standing who has received the Journeyman Degree, at least sixty (60) days prior to the convening of the Biennial Grand Session. Such proposals must be submitted in writing to the Grand Secretary, who shall distribute copies to all Grand Lodge officers and Constituent Lodges no less than thirty (30) days prior to the Session. During the Session, all

proposed resolutions and amendments shall be referred to the appropriate committee for review and recommendation before being presented for debate and vote before the assembled body. Adoption shall require the affirmative vote of a two-thirds majority of the registered members present and voting.

ARTICLE V: GRAND LODGE NOMINATIONS AND ELECTIONS

Section 5.01 Nominations and Elections. Grand Lodge shall announce the opening of nominations ninety (90) days before the Grand Lodge Session. Nominations shall be submitted by members (in good standing) from regularly chartered and commissioned lodges of the Grand Lodge. Nominations can be made from the floor during the appropriate order of business during the Grand Lodge Session. Nominations must be accepted sixty (60) days before the Grand Lodge Session and Candidate Profiles submitted 60 days the Grand Lodge Session, unless otherwise Stated in the by-laws of the Grand Lodge. No nominations will be accepted from the floor during Grand Lodge Sessions.

Section 5.02 Grand Lodge Election Committee. During the Grand Lodge Session, a three-person committee shall be appointed by the Most Worthy Grand Master to oversee the balloting process. The committee will consist of: Reader – responsible for reading each ballot aloud. Tallier – responsible for recording votes for each candidate. Overseer – responsible for verifying the name on each ballot once it has been read. Committee members may rotate roles after every fifty (50) ballots. The balloting shall proceed in the following order:

- (a) Current Grand Lodge officers
- (b) Members of the balloting committee
- (c) Remaining eligible members in attendance

The number of ballots distributed must match the number of ballots deposited in the ballot box. For electronic voting, the number of ballots cast must equal the number of members present during the election.

Section 5.03 Balloting. All elections shall be conducted using either electronic or paper ballots. In the case of paper ballots, a designated member shall read each ballot aloud, with two additional members assigned to verify the accuracy of the readings. Current Grand Lodge Officers and any candidates for office are strictly prohibited from serving on the Grand Lodge Election Committee to ensure impartiality and fairness. The designated Reader shall announce the total number of votes received by each candidate and declare the individual receiving the majority as the duly elected candidate.

Section 5.04 Installation. The installation of Grand Lodge Officers shall occur at the conclusion of the Grand Lodge Session, preferably during a formal banquet. Outgoing officers shall present the regalia of office to their duly elected successors. In cases where an officer continues in the same role, he may designate a non-member—such as a family member or friend—to present the regalia on his behalf. The installation ceremony shall be conducted by one of the following: a Past Worthy Grand Master, a Grand Master from another jurisdiction, or a

member of the Board of Grand Masters in attendance. The individual selected to perform the installation shall be formally invited by the current Most Worthy Grand Master no less than ninety (90) days in advance to ensure sufficient time for planning and attendance.

ARTICLE VI: BOARD OF GRAND MASTERS

Section 6.01 Establishment and Composition. There shall be established within the Grand Lodge a Board of Grand Masters, composed exclusively of members who have been conferred the Grand Master Gardner Degree. This Degree is bestowed exclusively upon newly elected Grand Masters and upon Past Master Gardener Degree Members by invitation from the Board, or recommendation of the sitting Most Worthy Grand Master, in recognition of distinguished service, leadership, and long-standing dedication to the Order. Outgoing Most Worthy Grand Masters shall remain members of the Board and be designated the honor of installing his predecessor.

Section 6.02 Purpose and Authority. The Board of Grand Masters shall function as a ceremonial and advisory body within the Grand Lodge. Its primary responsibilities include conducting the formal Grand Master's Degree Ceremony for the installation of each newly elected Most Worthy Grand Master, preserving the dignity and traditions associated with this rite of passage, and offering counsel to the Grand Lodge leadership.

Section 6.03 Advisory Role. The Board shall serve as a source of collective wisdom, experience, and institutional memory, providing guidance to the Most Worthy Grand Master on matters of governance, tradition, and the advancement of the Order. While advisory in nature, the counsel of the Board shall be regarded with respect and deference. Only a duly elected Worthy Grand Master shall be entitled to the privileges of his office; the title of Grand Master Gardener holds no authoritative power outside of the Board of Grand Masters.

Section 6.04 Meetings and Service. The Board shall meet at the call of the Most Worthy Grand Master, who serves as chair of the Board by virtue of his office, and as needed to fulfill its duties. Members of the Board may be requested to serve on select committees or special assignments consistent with their expertise and standing.

Section 6.05 Recognition and Preservation of Honor. Membership on the Board of Grand Masters shall be regarded as one of the highest honors within the Order. Its proceedings and ceremonial functions shall reflect the solemnity, dignity, and fraternal values that define the spirit and legacy of the Order.

CHAPTER III: CONSTITUENT LODGES AND INDEPENDENT LODGES

ARTICLE I: Name and operation

Section 1.01 Name. The official name, style, and title of a Constituent Lodge shall be: “[Name of Lodge] No. [sequential number assigned by the United Council], A.O.F.G. ([state/province, territory/nation]), and shall henceforth be governed by the following regulations.

Section 1.02 Organization. Lodges shall be established or reorganized in accordance with the provisions of this chapter. To more effectively fulfill their organizational purposes—particularly concerning the management of property entrusted to them—they are hereby authorized, as soon as practicable after their formation and at their discretion, to obtain corporate charters from the appropriate governmental authorities of the State, District, Territory, Province, or Nation in which they are located. These charters shall grant them legal status as corporate entities, empowering them to acquire, hold title to, and, if necessary, pursue legal action to recover such funds and property as fall within their jurisdiction.

Section 1.03 Purpose. To promote the principles of love, wisdom, harmony and truth in their community, and offer a space where members may learn, grow and work together for the interests of the membership and the Order.

Section 1.04 Objectives. To uphold and advance the principles of Love, Wisdom, Harmony, and Truth; and to cultivate an environment where seekers and Free Gardeners are encouraged to embark on a path of self-discovery and enlightenment, promoting their intellectual, moral, social, and spiritual growth; to promote programs and events which foster the stewardship of nature and the intellectual, moral, social and spiritual wellbeing of mankind.

Section 1.05 Interest of the United Council. The United Council of the Ancient Order of Free Gardeners shall retain a reversionary interest in all property, funds, ceremonial materials, and official records held by Grand Lodges and Independent Lodges. In the event of the voluntary or involuntary dissolution of a Grand Lodge, such assets shall be surrendered to the Council within thirty (30) days of the effective date of dissolution.

Section 1.06 Interest of the Grand Lodge. The Grand Lodge shall retain a reversionary interest in all property, funds, ceremonial materials, and official records held by Constituent Lodges. In the event of the voluntary or involuntary dissolution of a Lodge, such assets shall be surrendered to the Grand Lodge within thirty (30) days of the effective date of dissolution.

Section 1.07 Authority. Lodges shall have autonomy and exclusive authority over all concerns of their Lodge. Each Lodge shall adopt bylaws, using the prescribed template provided by the United Council, to govern their Lodge. Lodges shall have the authority to add sections to the prescribed by-laws template for the benefit of its membership. Lodge bylaws must not contradict the By-Laws of the Grand Lodge or the Constitution and By-Laws of the Ancient Order of Free Gardeners.

Section 1.08 Non-Interference Policy. The Grand shall not intervene in the internal affairs of any Constituent Lodge unless such involvement is specifically requested or deemed essential for the protection and welfare of the Order and its members. Similarly, the United Council shall not involve themselves in the business operations of Independent Lodges within, except when their assistance is requested or determined necessary for the Order's well-being. No Lodge may interfere in the affairs of another Lodge, unless expressly authorized by the Grand Lodge or the United Council to assist in the formation or reorganization of said lodge.

Section 1.09 Charters and Commissions. A Grand Lodge may be established or restructured upon submission of a formal petition for charter by at least five (5) Independent Lodges. Collectively, these lodges must include a minimum of eight (8) individuals who have attained the rank of Past Master Gardener and be located within the same State, Province, Nation, or Territory. Only one Grand Lodge may be chartered per geographic region—no more than one may exist within the same State, Province, Nation, or Territory. If the petitioning lodges do not meet the requirement of eight (8) Past Master Gardeners, they may be granted a provisional commission. This commission will remain in effect until the required number of eligible Master Gardeners has earned the Past Master's Degree. A quorum of at least four (4) Past Master Gardeners is required to vote on applications for Constituent lodge charters or commissions. Grand Lodges operating under a commission are not authorized to issue charters or commissions for Constituent lodges. All such applications must be submitted to and approved by the United Council until the Grand Lodge obtains an official charter or receives a special warrant authorizing such actions. Commissioned Grand Lodges must also maintain a quorum of at least four (4) Master Gardeners for operational proceedings.

Section 1.10 Lodge Hall. The official meeting place of a Lodge, including property owned, rented, or reserved for lodge use, shall be located in the area designated in the charter or commission, and may be changed at the discretion of the lodge and with due notice sent to the Grand Lodge and/or United Council.

ARTICLE II: LODGE OFFICERS

Section 2.01 Qualifications of Lodge Officers. All Lodge officers shall be duly elected or appointed members who have attained the Master Gardener's Degree. Journeyman Gardeners may be selected to serve in an appointed position including Lodge Committees, except where otherwise specified in the Lodge By-Laws

Section 2.02 Elected Officers. Elected officers shall be qualified members chosen by majority vote of the members of the Lodge. The elected positions shall include: Worthy Master; Emissary Master; Secretary; Rentmaster; Instruction Master.

Section 2.03 Appointed Officers. Appointed officers shall be qualified members chosen by the Worthy Master. The appointed positions shall include: Chaplain; Gatekeeper; Keyholder.

Section 2.04 Term of Grand Lodge Officers. Elected and appointed Grand Lodge officers shall serve for a term of two (2) years. No one may serve as Worthy Master or Emissary Master for more than two consecutive terms, unless special authorization from the Grand Lodge (or United Council for Independent Lodges) is granted after due cause is shown.

Section 2.05 Worthy Master. The duties of the Worthy Grand shall be to: Preside over all Lodge meetings, ensuring order, peace, and harmony throughout the proceedings; Serve as the highest-ranking Officer of the Lodge; Inspire members to contribute meaningfully to the Lodge and the broader community it serves; Ensure that the operations of the Lodge aligns with the Grand Lodge By-Laws, the Constitution and By-Laws of the Order, and all applicable national, state, provincial, or territorial laws and regulations; Appoint officers to serve during his

term; Select committee chairs to lead both standing and special committees; Fulfill any additional responsibilities as outlined by the Constitution and By-Laws of the Order, By-Laws of the Grand Lodge and By-Laws of the Lodge or prescribed in the Ceremonies of the Order.

Section 2.06 Emissary Master. The duties of the Emissary Master shall be to: Assist the Worthy Master in the execution of his duties and preside in his place in the event of his absence or removal; Represent the Worthy Master during visitations to other lodges and public engagements, when called upon; Serve as the public representative of the Lodge when meeting with other organizations or entities; Carry out any other duties as assigned by the Worthy Master or as directed by the Constitution and By-Laws of the Order, By-Laws of the Grand Lodge and By-Laws of the Lodge or prescribed in the Ceremonies of the Order.

Section 2.07 Secretary. The duties of the Secretary shall be to: Oversee all official communications of the Lodge, ensuring their receipt and proper distribution; follow any operations manual provided by the Grand Lodge or United Council that outlines the procedures essential to the daily functioning of the Lodge; Prepare agendas for the regular lodge meetings in collaboration with the Worthy Master; Appoint, with the approval of the Worthy Master, an Assistant to support him in clerical responsibilities; Keep accurate records of all Lodge proceedings; Submit annual reports to the Grand Lodge and United Council; Receive regular reports from Lodge Committees to be presented during lodge meetings; Perform any other duties as assigned by the Worthy Master or as directed by the Constitution and By-Laws of the Order, By-Laws of the Grand Lodge and By-Laws of the Lodge or prescribed in the Ceremonies of the Order.

Section 2.08 Rentmaster. The duties of the Rentmaster shall be to: Receive, safeguard, and disburse all funds belonging to the Lodge; Maintain accurate and up-to-date financial records, including ledgers, statements, and reports; preparing and presenting financial statements to the Lodge at its regular meetings or upon request of any member of said Lodge; Ensure that all expenditures are made in accordance with approved budgets and financial policies of the Lodge; Coordinate with the Financial Oversight Committee on matters relating to financial planning, audits, and fundraisers; Request guidance with financial compliance and reporting as needed; Perform any other financial duties as may be assigned by the Worthy Master or as directed by the Constitution and By-Laws of the Order, By-Laws of the Grand Lodge and By-Laws of the Lodge or prescribed in the Ceremonies of the Order.

Section 2.09 Instruction Master. The duties of the Instruction Master shall be to: Promote uniformity and accuracy in ceremonial practices and ceremonial work in the Lodge; Provide instruction and guidance to members of the Lodge on proper procedures, ensuring adherence to the traditions, ceremonies, and established protocols of the Order; Conduct educational sessions, training workshops, and demonstrations to enhance the knowledge and proficiency of Lodge officers and members; Serves as chair of the Ceremonial Standards Committee; Use approved instructional materials of the United Council and Grand Lodge; Support the overall mission of the Order by fostering excellence in ceremonial work and decorum; Perform any other duties as assigned by the Worthy Master or as directed by the Constitution and By-Laws of the Order or prescribed in the Ceremonies of the Order..

Section 2.10 Chaplain. The duties of the Chaplain shall be to: Provide spiritual and moral support and guidance to the members of the Lodge; Foster a sense of unity, compassion, and moral integrity; Offer invocations, benedictions, and other appropriate prayers or reflections at official gatherings, ceremonies, and special observances; Support members during times of personal hardship, illness, or bereavement by extending words of comfort and encouragement on behalf of the Lodge; Ensures that the spiritual traditions and moral values of the Order are upheld and reflected in Lodge activities; Coordinate memorial services and assist in promoting charitable efforts consistent with the Order's mission, when called upon to do so; Perform any other duties as assigned by the Worthy Master or as directed by the Constitution and By-Laws of the Order or prescribed in the Ceremonies of the Order.

Section 2.11 Gatekeeper. The duties of the Gatekeeper shall be to: Guard the outer gate (door) of the entrance to the Lodge when in session and maintain the integrity and security of the same; Ensure that only qualified members are admitted and that the ceremonial environment is preserved without interruption; direct members and guests as they enter and leave the Lodge when in session; Perform any other duties as assigned by the Worthy Master or as directed by the Constitution and By-Laws of the Order or prescribed in the Ceremonies of the Order.

Section 2.12 Keyholder. Guard the inner gate (door) of the entrance to the Lodge when in session and maintain the integrity and security of the same; Escort dignitaries, introduce visitors, and direct the physical arrangement of officers and regalia during closed or public ceremonies; Aid in maintaining decorum throughout all official functions, in accordance with the traditions and ceremonial standards of the Order; Perform any other duties as assigned by the Worthy Master or as directed by the Constitution and By-Laws of the Order or prescribed in the Ceremonies of the Order.

Section 2.13 Lodge Committees. The Lodge Committees shall include standing (permanent) and special (temporary). The Lodge, by resolution adopted by a majority vote of the Lodge Officers, may establish new standing committees based on the needs of the Lodge. Committees shall consist of at least three (3) members who have received the Master Gardener's degree of the Order. The following standing committees shall be perpetual and may never be dissolved: Ceremonial Standards, Growth and Expansion, Preservation and Instruction, Public Relations and Communications, and Financial Oversight. Each committee shall have such authority as the Lodge shall by resolution provide; except that no such committee shall have the ability to decide on matters to be addressed by the membership but may submit recommendations as a committee when called to do so by the Worthy Master or by virtue of the committee's designated duties. Ideal committee appointments are based on the experience and skills of the appointee.

Section 2.14 Quorum and Action by Committee. Unless otherwise provided by resolution of the Lodge or Grand Lodge (or United Council for Independent Lodges), three (3) or more members shall constitute a quorum for the transaction of business and the vote of a majority of a committee. The Committee Secretary in collaboration with the Committee Chair shall create and distribute a meeting agenda to accompany an official notice to all members of the Grand Lodge thirty (30) days before the date of the meeting, with a reminder seven (7) days before the date. The procedures of the committees shall be subject at all times to the directions of

the Worthy Master and in agreement with the bylaws of the Lodge, Grand Lodge and the Constitution and Bylaws of the Order.

Section 2.15 Alternate Members. The Worthy Master may designate one (1) or more Lodge officer as alternate members of any committee, who may replace any absent or disqualified member or members at any meeting of such committee.

Section 2.16 Lodge Committee Officers. Committees shall include an executive board consisting of a Committee Chair, Vice-Chair and Secretary.

Section 2.17 Duties of Committees. The duties of the standing Lodge committees are as follows:

(a) Ceremonial Standards Committee

- Preserves and promotes the correct use of ceremonial traditions.
- Provides guidance on initiation rites and ceremonial accuracy.
- Monitors adherence to ceremonial practices within the lodge.

(b) Growth and Expansion Committee

- Develops strategies for membership recruitment and retention.
- Coordinates lodge social events and fellowship retreats.
- Solicits recommendations from membership for programs and events.

(c) Preservation and Instruction Committee

- Maintains historical archives of the Lodge and promotes research into the order's origins.
- Organizes educational programs and public outreach centered around the stewardship of nature, community gardening, and the general teachings of the Order.
- Oversees initiatives to document and share the order's traditions.

(d) Public Relations and Communication Committee

- Manages external communications, branding, and public awareness efforts in accordance with the Brand Standard prescribed by the United Council.
- Oversees digital platforms, including websites and social media presence.
- Coordinates promotional and outreach initiatives.

(e) Financial Oversight Committee

- Ensures financial transparency within the Lodge.
- Develops fundraising programs to support Lodge initiatives.
- Advises Lodge on sustainable financial practices.

ARTICLE III: LODGE MEETINGS

Section 3.01 Regular Meetings. The Lodge shall convene in regular session on the day(s) and time(s) prescribed in its By-Laws. The specific date, time, and location of each

meeting shall be communicated to all members no less than thirty (30) days in advance, with a reminder of each meeting no later than three (3) days in advance.

(a) Annual Planning Meeting. An Annual Planning Meeting of the Lodge shall be held each January, on a date set by the Worthy Master, for the primary purpose of establishing the preliminary itinerary and strategic objectives for the forthcoming calendar year.

(i) Participants. This meeting shall include the elected and appointed Lodge officers, committee chairs, and any other individuals designated by the Worthy Master whose input is deemed essential to the planning process.

(ii) Agenda and Preparation. The agenda for the Annual Planning Meeting shall include, but not be limited to: review of the previous year's activities, scheduling of ceremonial and administrative events, setting of key deadlines for reports and initiatives, alignment of committee objectives, and discussion of resource needs. All officers and committee chairs shall be required to submit a summary of proposed goals or activities in advance of the meeting, as directed by the Secretary.

(iii) Reporting and Implementation. Outcomes of the Annual Planning Meeting shall be documented and circulated by the Secretary within ten (10) business days. The finalized itinerary and strategic plan shall serve as a foundational guide for the activities and obligations of the Lodge throughout the year, subject to amendment by vote at a regular lodge or committee meeting, if necessary.

Section 3.02 Resolutions and Amendments. Proposed resolutions and amendments to the Lodge By-Laws may be submitted by any member in good standing of said lodge who has received the Journeyman Degree. Such proposals must be submitted in writing to the Secretary, who shall distribute copies to all members Lodges no less than seven (7) days prior to the next regular meeting. During the meeting, all proposed resolutions and amendments shall be read aloud before and the floor will be open for a brief debate followed by call for a motion and vote. Adoption shall require the affirmative vote of a two-thirds majority of the Lodge members present and voting.

Section 3.03 Purpose. Regular meetings shall be held to conduct the official business of the Lodge, including but not limited to the reception of reports from officers and committees, review of financial statements, consideration of membership applications and correspondence, planning of upcoming events, performing degree ceremonies and the discussion and adoption of matters essential to the welfare of the Lodge.

Section 3.04 Quorum. A quorum for the transaction of business at any regular meeting shall consist of five (5) or more Journeyman and/or Master Gardeners (guests are not counted in the quorum).

Section 3.05 Notice and Agenda. The Secretary shall issue formal notice of each meeting, including a proposed agenda and relevant documentation, to all members not less than three (3) days prior to the meeting date.

Section 3.06 Committee Meetings. *[see Article II, Sections 14&15]*

ARTICLE IV: LODGE NOMINATIONS AND ELECTIONS

Section 4.01 Nominations and Elections. Lodge shall announce the opening of nominations at the first (1st) meeting in the fall during the last year of the current term. Nominations shall be submitted by members (in good standing) of said Lodge. Nominations can be made from the floor during the appropriate order of business during the meeting. Nominations must be before the next regular meeting and, unless otherwise Stated in the by-laws of the Grand Lodge. No nominations will be accepted from the floor on the day of elections. Elections will be held at the second (2nd) regular meeting in the fall.

Section 4.02 Lodge Election Committee. On the day of the elections, a three-person committee shall be appointed by the Worthy Master to oversee the balloting process. The committee will consist of: Reader – responsible for reading each ballot aloud. Tallier – responsible for recording votes for each candidate. Overseer – responsible for verifying the name on each ballot once it has been read. Committee members may rotate roles after every fifty (50) ballots. The balloting shall proceed in the following order:

- (a) Current Lodge officers
- (b) Members of the balloting committee
- (c) Remaining eligible members in attendance

The number of ballots distributed must match the number of ballots deposited in the ballot box. For electronic voting, the number of ballots cast must equal the number of members present during the election.

Section 4.03 Balloting. All elections shall be conducted using either electronic or paper ballots. In the case of paper ballots, a designated member shall read each ballot aloud, with two additional members assigned to verify the accuracy of the readings. Current Lodge Officers and any candidates for office are strictly prohibited from serving on the Lodge Election Committee to ensure impartiality and fairness. The designated Reader shall announce the total number of votes received by each candidate and declare the individual receiving the majority as the duly elected candidate.

Section 4.04 Installation. The installation of Lodge Officers shall take place at the last meeting of the year, or during a formal banquet to be held around the same time. Outgoing officers shall present the regalia of office to their duly elected successors. In cases where an officer continues in the same role, he may designate a non-member—such as a family member or friend—to present the regalia on his behalf. The installation ceremony shall be conducted by one of the following: a Past Worthy Master, Grand Lodge Officer, or Grand Master Gardener from

said lodge. The individual selected to perform the installation shall be formally invited by the current Worthy Master no less than thirty (30) days in advance to ensure sufficient time for planning and attendance.